



Toss-up between two: The third all-rounder's spot in India's T20I team is likely up for grabs, with Riyan Parag (in pic) and Washington as the contenders. AP

allowing it a left-right batting pair in the middle without much difficulty. This tactic meant the Sri Lankan bowlers had to constantly adjust their lines, resulting in erratic bowling and easier run-scoring opportunities.

Yashasvi Jaiswal and Shubman Gill offered renewed vigour at the top, while Suryakumar demonstrated his aggressive batting style, unaffected by the added responsibility of captaincy. Rishabh Pant and Hardik Pandya also made significant contributions with the bat when required.

The Indian bowlers were impressive, taking 27 out of 30 Sri Lankan wickets. Spinners Axar and Bishnoi continued to prove their reliability, with Bishnoi's three-wicket haul being crucial in India's win in the second game.

Bishnoi's sharp bowling has strengthened his position, and he may challenge the rested Kuldeep Yadav for the primary spinner role in the T20I setup.

Gambhir's decision to bench

all-rounder Washington Sundar for the first two games raised a few eyebrows initially given that many expected Sundar to replace the now-retired Ravindra Jadeja in the T20I unit. However, India chose Riyan Parag, a more reliable batting option, as the sixth bowler.

To his credit, Parag bowled with great heart, using a mix of off-breaks and leg spin to keep the Lankan batters guessing.

Washington, though, made the best of the only opportunity that came his way. He put in a man-of-the-match winning performance in the third T20I, taking two wickets after an innings-salvaging cameo of 25 (18).

A major blot in the Indian performance was Sanju Samson's failure to make his chances count. The Kerala batter tallied consecutive ducks and had a disappointing day behind the stumps in the third T20I.

Similarly, pacers Khaleel Ahmed and middle-order batter Shivam Dube too had forgettable outings in the third game.

For Sri Lanka, the series defeat, coming after a shock group-stage exit in the T20 World Cup, means a further drop into the abyss.

A weak middle-order, prone to consistent collapses, was the main

cause of Sri Lanka's downfall. In the three games, the Sri Lankan middle order (numbers four, five, six and seven) combined to score 61 runs for an abysmal average of 5.08.

It also didn't help that the home bowlers were consistently taken apart by the Indian batters, except in the third match, where a crumblingallekele surface came to their aid.

Nissanka's excellence with the bat (137 runs in three matches) was the lone bright spot for Sri Lanka. He received considerable support from fellow openers Kusal Mendis and Perera. The Lankan top three aggregated 354 runs at a more-than-handy average of 39.33. But their efforts ultimately proved insufficient.

With a quick turnaround between the two white-ball legs, Sri Lanka will be hoping for a change in luck in the ODIs, especially with the bat.

For India, the transition following the retirement of T20I stalwarts Rohit Sharma, Virat Kohli, and Jadeja couldn't have been any smoother. In Suryakumar, the side seems to have found the right leader going into the next T20 World Cup cycle. Most of the slots in the lineup are filled, with only the third all-rounder spot likely up for grabs, with Parag and Washington as the contenders.